# Ideation guidance

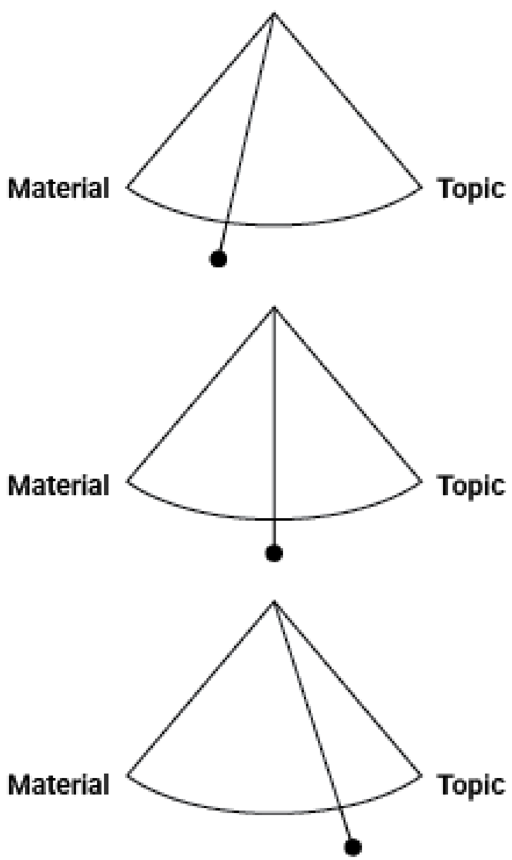
Guide provided in ‘Resources’ Module

# Finding Your Own Approach

## When generating ideas for experiments, there is no single "correct" way to start.

- Some of you may be more interested in the **technical, material, and craft aspects**, wanting to explore social connections through making.
- Others may feel drawn to **social issues** first, using design as a method to creatively respond to a topic that interests you.
- Many of you will fall somewhere in between.
  All approaches are valid!
- Over time you might shift your focus.

***The key is to start where you feel comfortable and stay open to new connections as you experiment.***



# Step 1: Start Broad – List Your Interests

**Begin by brainstorming a wide range of topics, skills, and materials that excite you.**

- **What excites you?** *(E.g., fashion, robotics, surfing, music, gaming, science fiction, politics?)*
- **What tools or techniques intrigue you?** *(E.g., laser cutting, hand-dyeing, projection mapping?)*
- **What materials do you want to explore?** *(E.g., biodegradable plastics, textiles, wood, metal, AR environments?)*

**Suggestion: Write down at least 10 different things that capture your curiosity.**

*If you are more making-driven, you can focus on materials & tools you want to play with.*

*If you are more theory-driven, list cultural, political, or ethical topics that intrigue you.*

*If you are more lifestyle-driven, focus on hobbies & activities you love!*

*Mix it up – don't focus on one area only.*

# Step 2: Connect Your Interests to Broader Domains

## Now, explore how your personal interests relate to broader social movements and issues.

If you're not sure where to start, think about how **design can contribute to meaningful change** and engage with **critical conversations** shaping the world today.

### Key Questions:

- What social movements, advocacy efforts, or systemic issues resonate with you?
- *E.g., climate justice, disability rights, mental health advocacy, decolonisation, regenerative design, ethical AI, gender, circular economies, food sovereignty, cultural preservation?*
- How do your interests connect to these movements and challenges?

*If you are more socially-driven, you might start with a movement or challenge and explore different ways to approach it through design.*

*If you are more technically-driven, you might begin with materials and tools and explore how they could intersect with a social movement.*

*Don't worry about DES304! This is a different course!*

# Step 2: Connect Your Interests to Broader Domains

## Example connections:

- **Textiles & Sustainability** → Creating biodegradable fashion using fungi-based textiles.
- **Food Science & Circular Economies** → Designing edible packaging to reduce waste.
- **Weaving & Cultural Preservation** → Digitally documenting endangered textile techniques.
- **Music & Accessibility** → Prototyping haptic sound experiences for the deaf and hard-of-hearing.
- **Surfing & Ocean Conservation** → Designing wax alternatives or biodegradable surfboard materials to reduce microplastic pollution.

**Suggestion: Create at least two connections per interest, considering how your passions align with social movements and where design could make an impact**

# Step 3: Generate 'What If?' Experiment Prompts

**Now that you have connections between personal interests, materials, tools, and social topics, start forming questions that spark experiments.**

- **What if I combined [Technique A] with [Material B]?**
  *(E.g., What if I used 3D printing to create flexible textiles?)*
- **What if I adapted a tool from another industry?**
  *(E.g., Could I use medical scanning techniques to create digital models for furniture?)*
- **What if I exaggerated a material property?**
  *(E.g., Could I design ultra-lightweight concrete structures?)*
- **What if I hacked an everyday object?**
  **(***E.g., Could I turn an old phone into a haptic feedback controller?)*

**Suggestion: Write down at least 15 'What if?' questions – go for quantity over quality!**

*You don't need to answer 'What if?' questions, they're speculative.*

*They can sound totally crazy and out of scope.*

*Don't get hung up on asking 'solvable' questions.*

*That's for later!*

# Step 4: Flip Perspectives & Combine Ideas

**Take your ideas further by reframing them or combining them in unexpected ways.**

- **Invert a challenge:** What if instead of making something more efficient, you made it intentionally slow? (E.g., A deliberately inefficient way to navigate a city?)
- **Blend two unrelated areas:** What if you mixed music production with architecture? (E.g., Buildings that react to sound?)
- **Scale it up or down:** What if a handheld product became a room-sized installation? (E.g., A giant interactive drawing machine?)

**Suggestion: Take at least five of your ‘What if?’ questions and alter them using these techniques.**

# Step 5: Examine connection to Brief

## Evaluate whether the interest areas and domains are related to the brief:

- **Categorise them**: Separate the areas in the range of closely related, loosely related and non-related.
- **Reframe:** For those loosely related, is there a way to adapt them so that it could be closer?

**Suggestion: Mark up all your ideas! Even if it is loosely related, there may be ways of enhancing the connection at a later stage.**

# Step 6: Final Idea List – Reach 20+ Concepts

**Now, combine everything you've generated so far into a final list of 20+ possible experiment ideas.**

- Include different levels of complexity (some quick tests, some longer explorations).
- Focus on playfulness and curiosity – pick something you will genuinely enjoy
- Try to interrogate this against your brief scoping and reverse brief, does it fit or do you need to re-evaluate?

**Suggestion: List out 20+ experiment ideas, then star (⭐) the top 3-5 you feel most excited about.**